GROWTH BLUEPRINT ADVISORY

Retail & E-commerce

The Saudi market-entry brief

THE SECTOR IN PLAIN WORDS

Before we start

Saudi shoppers are digital, mobile and used to choice. They compare prices, read reviews, and expect fast delivery and easy returns, often in Arabic. For retailers and online sellers, that creates a big opportunity, and a high bar for the basics.

This brief is for retailers, brands and marketplaces who want to sell in the Kingdom through stores, online or both. It covers channels, payments and delivery, the compliance points that catch overseas sellers out, and a first-year plan that keeps costs under control.

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Please note. This brief is general guidance written by advisers. It is not legal, tax or investment advice. Rules and programmes change, so confirm current requirements with the relevant authority and licensed advisers before you act. We do not include market-size statistics because they date quickly; ask us for current figures.

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What is driving demand

Digital adoption

High smartphone use and trust in online payment support fast e-commerce growth.

Evolving payments

Local payment schemes, wallets and instalment options shape conversion.

Retail destinations

New malls, districts and experiences are changing how people shop.

Logistics investment

Better fulfilment and last-mile options make faster delivery realistic.

03

How the market is organised

The market at a glance.

Who shops	A young, connected population, with strong mobile use and growing comfort with online payment.
Where they shop	Malls and high streets, marketplaces, brand sites, social commerce and quick-delivery apps.
How they pay	Local debit cards and wallets, cards, cash on delivery in some segments, and buy-now-pay-later.
What decides success	Price, trust, delivery speed, easy returns and an excellent Arabic experience.
Typical first move	Test demand through a marketplace or a pilot site before investing in stores.

04

Ways in

Marketplaces

Quick and low fixed cost. You compete on price and reviews and share your margin.

Own site with a local fulfilment partner

More control of brand and data. Needs marketing, delivery and customer service.

Franchise or distribution partner

A local operator runs stores or online sales. Fast scale, less control.

Own stores

High investment, high visibility. Suits brands with proven demand.

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Rules to check early

Confirm these early, with the relevant authority and a licensed adviser.

- [ ] Consumer protection, e-commerce and returns rules, and any registration for online sellers.
- [ ] Import conformity and labelling requirements for the products you sell.
- [ ] VAT and e-invoicing obligations, including requirements on invoice format.
- [ ] Rules on advertising, influencer content and claims.
- [ ] Localisation expectations in retail roles, and rules on working hours and licensing for stores.

06

Partners: who you will meet

Marketplace operators

Understand fees, rules on pricing and how they treat sellers.

Payment providers

Choose partners that support local methods and instalments.

Fulfilment and last-mile partners

Check coverage, speed, returns handling and cost per order.

Mall owners and landlords

Lease terms, footfall evidence and turnover rents deserve scrutiny.

07

Where people go wrong

Weak Arabic experience

Machine translation and poor right-to-left design put off customers.

Ignoring local payment methods

Missing the methods people prefer costs conversions.

Underestimating returns

Returns are part of the model and need processes and budget.

Spending on marketing before delivery works

Great ads cannot fix late parcels.

Long leases too early

Prove demand before committing to space.

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Your first 90 days

Days 1 to 30: learn

- Shop the market as a customer: browse, buy, return.
- Note prices, delivery times and payment options for comparable products.
- Confirm conformity, labelling and tax steps.

Days 31 to 60: pilot

- Launch a small range on a marketplace or pilot site.
- Choose payment and fulfilment partners.
- Prepare Arabic content and customer service.

Days 61 to 90: learn from data

- Review conversion, delivery and returns.
- Adjust range and price.
- Decide how to scale, or whether to stop.

09

Questions to ask before you commit

Take these into your next meeting. If you cannot answer one, that is your next piece of homework.

- [ ] Who is our first customer, and where do they already shop?
- [ ] Which channel gives us the fastest, cheapest test?
- [ ] Which payment methods must we support to convert well?
- [ ] How fast and reliable is delivery on our key routes?
- [ ] What is our returns policy, and what does it cost?
- [ ] Is our Arabic content written for Saudi readers, not translated?
- [ ] What does a customer cost to win, and what do they earn us over a year?
- [ ] What results in 90 days would make us expand?

ملخص بالعربية

التجزئة والتجارة الإلكترونية: موجز دخول السوق السعودي

يعرض هذا الموجز كيف يتسوق العميل السعودي رقميًا وعبر المتاجر، وكيف تختار القنوات وطرق الدفع وشركاء التوصيل، وما نقاط الامتثال التي تفاجئ البائعين من الخارج. ستجد فيه أخطاء شائعة مثل التجربة العربية الضعيفة وإهمال طرق الدفع المحلية وتقدير تكلفة الإرجاع، وخطة لأول ٩٠ يومًا. وخلاصتنا: اختبر الطلب عبر سوق إلكتروني أو موقع تجريبي قبل الاستثمار في المتاجر، وتأكد من جاهزية التوصيل قبل الإنفاق على التسويق.

هذا الموجز إرشاد عام كتبه مستشارون، وليس مشورة قانونية أو ضريبية أو استثمارية. تتغير الأنظمة والبرامج، فتأكد دائمًا من المتطلبات الحالية مع الجهة المختصة ومستشارين مرخّصين.